

is most famous for a heart-stopping moment in which a girl appears to have her eyeball sliced open. The movie is a montage of strange scenes with no apparent connection, but Buñuel was later eager to stress that there is no symbolism in this movie. He said that the eyeball scene came from a dream, and that its meaning can only be established through psychoanalysis.

See also: *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* 208–09

FREAKS

Tod Browning, 1932

Tod Browning's disturbing US horror movie *Freaks* was banned in the UK for 30 years because of the way it seemed to exploit the physical attributes of its cast, who worked in a circus sideshow. It has since become a cult classic. At a circus, Cleopatra, a beautiful trapeze artist, agrees to marry the dwarf Hans in order to poison him and take his money. But her plan is foiled and the circus's other "freaks" take their revenge on her in a truly gruesome way. The original movie was destroyed, and only the marginally less unsettling cut version still exists. The movie ruined Browning's career.

THE GRAPES OF WRATH

John Ford, 1940

Based on John Steinbeck's 1939 novel, *The Grapes of Wrath* is set in Oklahoma, in the Depression years of the 1930s. It tells the story of the Joad family, who lose their farm and journey across the US to California in search of a better life. The movie pares the narrative of

the book down to focus on the family and their endurance against the odds. As Ma Joad says at the end: "They can't wipe us out, they can't lick us. We'll go on forever, Pa, 'cause we're the people." The movie marked the first major success for Henry Fonda, who played Tom Joad.

See also: *The Searchers* 135

THE MALTESE FALCON

John Huston, 1941

Humphrey Bogart played hard-bitten private detective Sam Spade as if born to the role in John Huston's *The Maltese Falcon*, a stylish and atmospheric thriller. Spade was an entirely new kind of hero, a tough guy who never yields for a moment to sentimentality, and Huston's low-key, shadowy lighting, and often startling camera angles, brilliantly created the movie's shady world. *The Maltese Falcon* is considered the first American film noir. It turned Bogart into a superstar and launched Huston's career as a major Hollywood director.

SULLIVAN'S TRAVELS

Preston Sturges, 1941

Sullivan's Travels is a witty send-up of pretentious filmmakers who make socially worthy drama. Young director John "Sully" Sullivan (Joel McCrea) is renowned for his frothy comedies, but goes on the road disguised as a tramp in order to gather material for a serious movie about the downtrodden. He meets the Girl (Veronica Lake), who hopes to be an actress, and soon realizes that making comedies that take people's minds off their worries is of more social use than a serious movie with a profound message.

MESHES OF THE AFTERNOON

Maya Deren and Alexander Hammid, 1943

Ukrainian-born choreographer Maya Deren was one of the most important experimental filmmakers of the post-World War II years, and *Meshes of the Afternoon*, made with her husband Alexander Hammid, is a landmark of the avant-garde. It lasts just 18 minutes, and, through unsettling camera angles, spirals through the dreams of a woman falling asleep at home, where ordinary objects—a knife, a key—become frightening and surreal in her subconscious. The revelation that movie could explore the workings of the mind in this way was hugely influential.

DOUBLE INDEMNITY

Billy Wilder, 1944

Billy Wilder's *Double Indemnity* uses the classic film noir setup, with a femme fatale, shabby motives, betrayal, and murder; however, the movie has romance at its heart. An ordinary insurance man is persuaded by a beautiful blonde (Barbara Stanwyck) to issue an insurance policy in her husband's name, and then to murder him in a staged accident, but the plan unravels horribly as each believes the other has betrayed them. The movie gains an edge by casting against type: Fred MacMurray, so often Mr. Nice Guy in Disney movies, plays the seedy insurance man; while Edward G. Robinson, so often the gangster, plays the decent investigator.

See also: *Sunset Boulevard* 114–15 ■ *Some Like It Hot* 148–49